MSI CD-RW CR52-A2

A genuine performer

MSI (Micro Star International) has recently released an internal 52x52x24x—the successor to the DragonWriter 48x16x48x.

It is bundled with Nero burning software, four mounting screws, one 52X CD-R, one 24X CD-RW, an analogue audio cable and an installation guide. The front panel has the standard oval-shaped buttons for play and eject, a headphone output and a volume control. The tray interface is also smooth and fast, and can be placed both horizontally and vertically.

This drive comes with a 2 MB buffer and BURN-Proof technology. The average user won't be able to exploit the writer's maximum speed, as 52X CD-Rs and 24X CD-RWs are difficult to find in India. Other features include Enhanced eXtracting and Adapting Control Technology (EXACT-Rec), which monitors the accuracy of data transfer and Advanced Weighting Suspension System(AHWSS), which reduces vibration and noise.

The drive runs with hardly any noise or errors, and the performance is quite commendable. Although the read speed was a problem for the 52X medium, it was not a problem for other media at speeds below 52X. It offers good stability and performance for those who need quick burning speeds, especially if you are raring to take advantage of the CD-Rs that support 790 MB of storage, which translates to 90 minutes of recorded music.

Price: Rs 4,100
Contact: Cyberstar Infocom Limited
Phone: 080-2276986
Fax: 080-2236781
E-mail: narend@cyberstarin.net
Website: www.msicomputer.com

SPECIFICATIONS

52X write, 24X re-write, 52X read speeds, IDE interface, 2 MB buffer, Exact-Rec and AWSS technology, BURN-proof, supports up to 790 MB disc capacity, horizontal and vertical mounting

MSI CD-RW CR52-A2	B+
Performance	
Build Quality	
Value for money	
Features	
OVERALL	

Apacer Audio Steno

The next step in portable audio players

The Apacer Audio Steno MP3 player functions as both, a voice recorder and a portable USB flash drive. It has a capacity of 128 MB, but there is no provision for expansion.

It is an attractive combination of silver and blue colours—an USB extension cable and an new look earphone attached to a sling are bundled along.

The player menu is well-structured, and allows easy access to all features. The player also offers preset equalizer settings such as Rock, Pop, Classical, etc. It can store around 125 minutes of listening time. The player LCD screen also changes to an equalizer band during music playback.

As a voice recorder, the microphone is quite powerful, and can record for a maximum of 10 hours. When used as an external drive, the copying, writing and reading data of 128 MB took less than 150 seconds—this is as quick as any USB flash drive of the same capacity.

A major setback is the fact that memory expansion is not possible. Although 64 MB players are available, they are cheaper only by Rs 1,000, making this product a better bargain.

Price: Rs 7,900
Contact: Xserve India
Phone: 080-5572601
Fax: 080-5572603
E-mail: info@xserves.com
Web site: www.apacer.com

SPECIFICATIONS

USB 1.1, 128 MB Flash memory, five equalizer modes, five repeat options, Digital voice recording in Microsoft ADPCM format at 4 bit 8 KHz mono (4 Kbps), LCD display, one AAA battery, MP3 and WMA format supported

Apacer Audio Steno	A-
Performance	
Build Quality	
Value for money	
Features	
OVERALL	

CD Architect 5.0

DJ kid gloves

Sonic Foundry has released CD Architect 5.0 that supports the Red Book specification (CD-DA compliant) and allows PQ coding; independently setting your own track IDs.

The single-user license does not have any restriction on the number of installations; the catch being that it should never be run concurrently on more than one machine.

One of the things going for CD Architect 5.0 is that it lets you import songs stored in multiple file formats into your project directly, thereby saving you the trouble of converting everything into a single format.

On the flipside, the program installs an MPEG-2 Directshow decoder that works fine with Windows Media Player, but might cause problems with some other applications.

Another disappointment is the lack of support for audio editing. Although there are menus for audio editing, you need to specify an external audio editor to get going.

While burning your track onto the disc, it calculates all the special effects and crossfades in real time. This could be a problem for slower computers.

This program performs decently, but its high price might make buyers think twice.

Price: Rs. 9,950, local taxes extra
Contact: Pro-Music Inc
Phone: 044-28193607
Fax: 044-28193823
E-mail: promusic@vsnl.com
Web site: www.sonicfoundry.com

SPECIFICATIONS

400 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, 40 MB free disk space, CD-Recordable drive, 24-bit colour display, Windows compatible sound card, Windows 98 SE, 2000,Me,XP, DirectX Media 8.0 Run Time.

CD Architect 5.0	B+
Performance	
Ease of Use	
Value for money	
Features	
OVERALL	